



Age-Related Macular Degeneration (AMD)

Age-related macular degeneration (AMD) is a common eye condition that affects the macula, the part of the retina responsible for central vision. It can make it harder to read, recognize faces, or drive, especially in older adults.

Types of AMD

- Dry AMD (most common – ~90% of cases): Caused by gradual thinning of the macula over time.
- Wet AMD (less common but more severe): Caused by abnormal blood vessels growing under the retina that can leak and cause rapid vision loss.

Symptoms

- Blurred or fuzzy central vision
- Straight lines appearing wavy
- Difficulty reading or recognizing faces
- A dark or blank spot in the center of vision

Peripheral (side) vision is usually not affected.

Risk Factors

- Age over 50
- Smoking
- Family history of AMD
- High blood pressure or cardiovascular disease
- Poor diet low in leafy greens or antioxidants
- Excessive sun exposure

Diagnosis

AMD is diagnosed with a full eye exam that may include:

- Dilated exam to view the macula
- OCT scan (optical coherence tomography) for detailed retina imaging
- Amsler Grid test to detect distortion
- Fluorescein angiography (for wet AMD)



Treatment Options

There is no cure for AMD, but treatments can help slow progression and preserve vision.

Dry AMD:

- Healthy diet (leafy greens, omega-3s, antioxidants)
- AREDS2 vitamins (if recommended)
- Stop smoking, protect eyes from UV

Wet AMD:

- Anti-VEGF injections: Given directly into the eye to stop abnormal vessel growth, often done monthly or every 1–3 months
- Occasionally, laser treatment

Living with AMD

- Regular follow-up and imaging
- Use high-contrast reading lights and magnifiers
- Monitor your vision with an Amsler Grid at home
- Ask about vision rehabilitation services

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Can AMD cause blindness?

A: It can cause significant central vision loss, especially in the wet form, but rarely leads to complete blindness.

Q: Are the injections painful?

A: Most patients feel only mild pressure — the eye is numbed beforehand.

Q: Will glasses fix my vision?

A: Glasses can help with general vision, but they don't treat AMD itself.